

Taking to the Stage

Non-fiction

Have you ever wanted to be someone different? If so, why not have a go at acting? There are lots of reasons to give it a try. As well as being lots of fun, it can be a great way to meet new friends and learn some very useful skills.

Early performers

Taking to the stage is something that people have been doing for thousands of years. The ancient Greeks were the earliest actors. One player, Thespis, is thought to have been the first ever person to have played a part as someone else – not as himself. That is why actors are sometimes called 'thespians', even now.

These days, top actors enjoy great fame and wealth. For some actors, they love performing as someone else. Others are tempted by the idea of the money and glamorous lifestyle. Most actors will tell you that it is not an easy job though!

Bad reputation

People haven't always respected actors as we do nowadays. Before the days of Queen Elizabeth I, they were widely seen as being little better than tramps and crooks. In England, only men and boys were allowed to act because it was not thought to be a decent job.

Acting changed a great deal for the better when the famous writer, William Shakespeare, arrived on the scene. Being an actor became much more acceptable and people even started to build permanent theatres in towns and cities for people to visit.

Screen actors

For the last hundred years or so, theatres have had to compete with film and TV. These inventions meant that it was easier for people to see the world's greatest stars without having to travel farther than their local cinema. It did mean, however, that actors had to adapt their skills. After all, on a stage your actions and voice must be louder than life so that they can be seen and heard by the people at the back. On screen, on the other hand, the camera can be so close that even the smallest movement will be clearly noticed.

What you need:

Acting might have changed over the centuries, but the basic skills you need remain the same:

- A good imagination
- The confidence to perform in front of crowds
- The ability to remember lots of lines
- A clear, interesting voice

Advice for getting started:

When your school is putting on a show, make sure that you audition for a part. If you don't have any luck, try to find out if there are any drama groups in your area. Alternatively, you could search the internet for local acting clubs for young people.